

THE ULTIMATE EXPERIMENT

With big prize money, shorter formats and presentation innovations, World Athletics is **reimagining** how track and field can capture a new generation of fans.

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Athletics is arguably the most global of sports, yet the feeling that it needs to be made more palatable for a TV audience with a shorter attention span continues to linger.

World Athletics, former track and field stars, streaming platforms and sports equipment giants have all tried their hand at producing spectacles and packaging the action in a manner that grabs maximum eyeballs. Consequently, athletes are seeing the kind of money no one could have dreamt of even a decade ago.

The latest in a series of experiments to raise the sport's profile was the inaugural World Athletics Ultimate Championships, held in Budapest from September 11 to 13.

The idea of having such an event as the season finale for 2026 was first made official around two months before the Paris Olympics, where another historic first took place, with every gold medallist receiving USD 50,000 in prize money from World Athletics.

"World Athletics today announced the launch of the World Athletics Ultimate Championship, a groundbreaking new global championship event set to transform the athletics calendar and define which athlete is the best of the best – pitting world champions, Olympic champions, the Diamond League winners and the year's best performing athletes against each other, to crown the ultimate champion," it said in an official release.

It would have taken a lot of convincing for the crème de la crème of track and field to show up at an event such as this in a year that otherwise featured neither the Summer Games nor the World Championships if it wasn't for a huge incentive — a total prize pool of USD 10 million, the highest in track and field history.

"It's the most money I've ever earned in 11 seconds," said American hurdler and world-record holder Masai Russell after receiving USD 150,000 for winning the women's 100m hurdles on the first day.

Usain Bolt, the sprint legend who came on board as an ambassador for the event, remarked cheekily: "I won a few championships and it still does not add up to all the cash."

For the 61,671 spectators at the Gyula Zsivotzky National Athletics Centre in Budapest, a three-hour show was carefully crafted by the organisers every night. The majority of the events had direct finals.

A series of innovations was also introduced to generate more interest. A day before the 200m semifinals, sprinters could select their